

RESEARCH & INTELLIGENCE TOOLS

Redditor Synthesizer

Read what a community actually wrote. Know who they are.
Ask them anything — a 385-person research panel for the
price of a coffee.

In This Issue

A field guide to turning any online community into a research panel — the problem it solves, how it works, and how to run it end to end.

01	The Problem	Why research panels are slow, expensive, and dishonest	03
02	The Solution	Four capabilities, one data backbone	04
03	Value Proposition	What used to cost a research firm	05
04	Core Concepts	Five ideas that unlock the whole tool	06
05	Use Cases	Six jobs this tool is built to do	07
06	Pipelines I — Pulse & Sample Size	Orientation in minutes	08
07	Pipelines II — Personas & Survey	Building and querying the panel	09
08	Bonus — Rounds of Surveys	Where the tool compounds	10
09	The Playbook I	Orientation & first research panel	11
10	The Playbook II	Full study & iterative intelligence	12
11	Reading Results Without Fooling Yourself	Six rules baked into the workflow	13
12	Honest Limitations	What this tool is not	14
13	Proof — Real Runs	What we've learned in the field	15
14	Getting Started & Roadmap	60 seconds to your first report	16

RESEARCH & INTELLIGENCE

The expensive bottleneck

Product teams, marketers, and researchers share the same problem: finding out what a group of people actually thinks.

TRADITIONAL METHOD	COST	SPEED	THE FLAW
Survey panels	\$2,000–\$10,000+	2–6 weeks	People answer what they think you want to hear
Focus groups	\$5,000–\$15,000+	3–8 weeks	8 people ≠ a market; groupthink contaminates
Social listening dashboards	\$1,000–\$30,000/yr	Realtime volume	Tells you what is discussed — never who or how they think
"Just talk to customers"	Free	Fast	Anecdotes, not evidence; survivorship bias

The people you want to understand are already writing their unfiltered opinions — every day, in public, on Reddit. Not what they'd say in a survey, but how they actually talk: complaints, values, trade-offs, vocabulary, hot buttons.

The real gap

The problem isn't that the data doesn't exist. It's that nobody has a way to turn raw public writing into a usable, statistical research panel — until now.

PRODUCT OVERVIEW

One data backbone, four capabilities

Redditor Synthesizer reads a community's public archive, builds detailed profiles of its most active members, then lets you run surveys on that population as a simulation — fast, cheap, and grounded in real evidence.

#	CAPABILITY	WHAT YOU GET	THINK OF IT AS
1	Pulse	A one-page "newspaper" of the community: hot topics, mood, what changed this week	Community weather report
2	Sample Size	A deterministic answer: how many people do I need to study for trustworthy results?	Statistician on demand
3	Personas	Detailed profiles of 20–400+ community members — style, values, Big Five traits, evidence anchors	A focus group you can keep
4	Synthetic Surveys	Simulated answers to your survey questions, from each persona's perspective	A test market before you build

How it holds together

All four capabilities run on the same local files. Everything is a single HTML report you open in a browser — no database, no dashboard, no vendor lock-in. Build the panel once with Personas; query it forever with Synthetic Surveys.

WHY IT WORKS

What used to cost a research firm

For the price of a coffee, get what a \$10,000 study used to take weeks to deliver.

DIMENSION	TRADITIONAL	REDDITOR SYNTHESIZER
Speed	Weeks	Hours — pulse in minutes, full study in a day
Cost	\$2,000–\$30,000	~ \$1–\$20 of AI tokens (free heuristic mode)
Scale	8–50 respondents	385-person panel (±5% at 95% confidence)
Grounding	Self-reported intentions	Real public writing — every profile anchored in quotes
Reusability	Survey ends, panel disappears	Personas persist — unlimited survey rounds
Privacy	Respondent data held by vendors	Public archive + local processing, nothing uploaded
Honesty	Numbers look clean	Built-in warnings — simulations labeled, confidence stated

Tell me what a community is talking about, who the people are, and what they'd say about your idea — in hours, for pocket change, with the receipts to prove it.

THE 30-SECOND PITCH

FIELD NOTES

Five ideas that unlock the tool

Understanding these five terms is enough to use everything that follows.

- 1 The Archive — raw material**

Reddit Synthesizer reads the Arctic Shift archive, a public, searchable copy of Reddit history. No scraping, no API keys, no ToS risk. The archive is the raw ore.
- 2 The Persona — the unit of research**

A synthesized profile of one real community member, built from ~30 of their actual comments: communication engine, Big Five personality, signature phrases, worldview. An evidence-anchored profile, not a vibe.
- 3 The Corpus — your panel**

20–400+ personas from one community. Built once, reusable forever. This is the asset the rest of the workflow compounds against.
- 4 The Instrument — your questions**

Any survey question set — 2 questions or 12, Likert scales, NPS, single-choice, open text — written in a simple JSON file.
- 5 The Simulation — the answer**

Each persona "answers" your instrument as themselves, drawing on their engine, values, and quotes. The aggregate is a simulated distribution with honest margins and explicit "not fielded" labeling.

— IN THE FIELD

Six jobs, one panel

A**Product validation before you build**

Ask 385 simulated members of the target community what they think — and why. Open-text answers surface objections before you spend a dollar.

B**Positioning & messaging testing**

Run a head-to-head instrument: which line wins, which value pillar matters, which offer they'd buy today. Stated preference is nice; revealed intent is the truth.

C**Market & demand sensing**

What is a community complaining about? What do they wish existed? Pulse gives you the demand signals; personas tell you who feels them most.

D**Investor & stakeholder evidence**

Walk in with n=385 simulated respondents, an NPS score, a preference split, and their exact words. That's a credibility asset.

E**Community intelligence for growth**

Launching into a subreddit? Know its culture first — themes, tone, intent, and the people who shape it.

F**Academic / research rehearsal**

Test hypotheses and instruments on a synthetic population before fielding a real study — cheap pilot, calibrated expectations.

INSTRUCTION MANUAL

Pipeline 1 & 2

Know what a community cares about, and how many people you'd need to study it — before you say a word.

Pipeline 1 — Pulse what's happening (minutes)

```
python reddit-intel/scripts/pulse.py \  
  --subreddit stocks --limit 30 --top 5 \  
  --out pulse-stocks.html
```

Opens as a one-page intelligence brief: top posts, themes (frequency vs. engagement), sentiment, intent, and "what changed this week." **Use it when you need orientation fast.**

Pipeline 2 — Sample Size how many people (seconds)

```
python reddit-intel/scripts/sample_size.py \  
  --subreddit stocks --confidence 95 --margin 5 \  
  --html-out sample-size-stocks.html
```

A deterministic calculator with a plain-English brief: "With N population at 95% / $\pm 5\%$, we think X and we recommend pull + pilot." **Use it before every study to size the panel.**

 INSTRUCTION MANUAL

Pipeline 3 & 4

Build the panel once. Query it as many times as you have questions.

Pipeline 3 — Personas who the people are (hours)

```
python reddit-intel/scripts/build_dataset.py \  
  --subreddit stocks --users 20 --comments-per-user 30 \  
  --out dataset-stocks --model deepseek-v4-flash --concurrency 2
```

Builds N persona dossiers + a control-panel index + `personas.jsonl` (the reusable corpus). **Use it once per community; the corpus is your asset.**

Pipeline 4 — Synthetic Survey what they'd say (30 min – 2.5 hrs)

```
python reddit-intel/scripts/synthetic_survey.py \  
  --personas dataset-stocks/personas.jsonl \  
  --out survey-stocks --model deepseek-v4-flash --concurrency 2
```

Simulates your instrument on every persona, checkpointed and resume-safe, outputs a report plus aggregates. **Use it every time you have a new question.**

WHERE IT COMPOUNDS

Keep asking

Once a corpus exists, run unlimited instruments against it — positioning, pricing, feature preference — via `ai_use_survey.py`. No new fetching. Each round is roughly 30 minutes.

The compounding loop

1×

BUILD THE CORPUS

∞

SURVEY ROUNDS

~30m

PER NEW QUESTION

This is where Redditor Synthesizer stops being "one report" and becomes standing infrastructure. Build the 385-person panel once for r/parenting; run your usefulness survey this week, your pricing survey next month, your positioning test the month after — against the exact same, already-grounded population.

Why this matters

Every other research method starts from zero each time. A corpus is capital — it appreciates the more questions you ask it.

STEP BY STEP

Level 1 & 2

Level 1 — Community orientation 30 minutes

1 Run Pulse on your target subreddit

Read the themes & mood.

2 Run Sample Size

Know the N you'd need.

3 Read the methodology note.

Done.

GOAL — know what the community cares about before you say a word.

Level 2 — First research panel half a day

1 Pulse the subreddit.

2 Build personas

Start with 20 (- - users 20) as a pilot.

3 Write a simple 2–5 question instrument.

4 Pilot the survey

On a random 20 rich personas first (~2 min). Catches instrument design flaws for ~5% of full-run cost. Warning: if a pilot column hits 100%, that's instrument artifact, not market truth.

5 Scale if direction looks sensible.

Build 385 personas, run the full survey.

GOAL — a credible first read with margins you can quote.

STEP BY STEP

Level 3 & 4

Level 3 — Full study, narrative report 1–2 days

1 Build the full corpus.

385 personas $\approx \pm 5\%$ @ 95% for large communities.

2 Run your core instrument.

12-Q usefulness, positioning, pricing.

3 Read the aggregates.

Which pillar wins, which offer converts, what's the NPS.

4 Wrap it in a narrative report.

Editorial voice + design system, for stakeholders.

5 Pair with the Hormozi reading.

The offer they'd buy today beats what they say they like.

GOAL — a decision-grade deliverable with receipts.

Level 4 — Iterative product intelligence ongoing

1 Keep the corpus.

Each new question = a new round (~30 min).

2 Track signals across rounds.

Did repositioning move the NPS? Which blocker faded?

3 Calibrate against reality.

When the product ships, field a small real survey.

GOAL — research that compounds instead of restarting.

— WITHOUT FOOLING YOURSELF

Six rules, hard-won

These rules are baked into the workflow for a reason — we've been burned by each.

1. Synthetic ≠ fielded

Simulated answers are a well-informed rehearsal, not real customers. The report says so; you should too.

2. Direction over spread at pilot scale

A 20-person pilot tells you which way the wind blows. Only quote percentages at full n.

3. 100% columns are red flags, not wins

When every persona picks the same option, the question design is too kind — it dissolved the top fear. Force trade-offs if spread matters.

4. "Why" matters more than "what"

The one-line justifications are where the actual insight lives.

5. Watch the buy-today question, not the like-it question

Stated preference is cheap; revealed intent is the signal.

6. Check the heuristic count

If the AI key is missing, you get lexicon-based guesses, not synthesis. Verify `heuristic_count: 0` before quoting.

FIELD NOTES

What this tool is not

Every research instrument has edges. Here are ours, stated plainly.

Reddit is not the whole market

The tool studies one community; generalize only with care.

Language $\approx$ attitude > behavior

What people say they'd do is not what they do. The tool models the former.

Base-model guardrails apply

You can't hand the personas to a generic AI chat and ask for segmentation — general assistants decline. The survey pipeline does the synthesis with full control instead.

Archive coverage varies

Very new or very small subreddits may have thin data; the sample-size pipeline accounts for this automatically.

Honesty is a feature. Every report ships with its own margins, its own warnings, and a place where the numbers admit what they can't tell you.

FROM REAL RUNS

What we've learned in the field

Each run below produced a shareable HTML report and the raw data behind it. Nothing is hidden in a database.

STUDY	WHAT WE RAN	WHAT IT TOLD US
r/parenting 2026-08	385 personas, 12-Q UCC Hermes survey	File-first ownership is the wedge (6.01/7, 81% top-2-box); setup friction is the killer (87% blocker); NPS -52.6 → the market wants a free 20-min test drive, not a platform pitch
r/parenting positioning pilot 2026-08	7-Q instrument, n=20	"The 20-Minute Answer" beats "Family Fortress" and "Concierge" 90/5/0; proof (65%) matters more than speed (30%) — the direction became the go-to-market
r/stocks earlier	20 personas, evidence-stack survey	Evidence framing scored 6.7/7, 100% top-2-box — a strong signal for a data-first product
r/parenting AI- use 2026-08	2-Q survey, n=383	90% of parents already use AI themselves; 86.5% are conditional about kids' AI — the self/kid gap is the product opening

60 SECONDS

Get started

```
# 1. Get the code
git clone https://github.com/alanism/redditor_synthesizer.git
cd redditor_synthesizer

# 2. (Recommended) add an AI key — makes reports much smarter
export DEEPSEEK_API_KEY=your-key-here

# 3. Run your first community report (swap "stocks" for any subreddit)
python reddit-intel/scripts/pulse.py --subreddit stocks --limit 30 --top 5 --out
pulse.html

# 4. Open pulse.html in any browser. That's it.
```

Requirements: Python 3.9+, no extra packages. Reports are single-file HTML — open offline, share freely.

Roadmap ideas

- **Multi-community notebooks** — query several subreddits' corpora together (cross-community QA)
- **Fielded calibration kit** — a guided path to run a small real survey and measure simulation-vs-reality drift
- **Templates library** — drop-in instruments (positioning, pricing, NPS, feature-preference) for common jobs
- **Scheduled intelligence** — cron-driven weekly pulses for communities you watch

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